

CHAPTER 13

IDENTIFICATION OF RAMAN SRIVASTAVA

'No, I don't know him.'

10 December 1994. Around 8.30 am, the Rajdhani Express rolled into Madras Central. It was a familiar station for me. I had been here several times, one of the memorable occasions being in 1967 when I was on my way to the Ammunition Factory in Kirkee, Maharashtra.

Stepping out of the train, it was a pleasant experience to be not mobbed by people and media. It must have been the same feeling for the CBI officers. We got into a Tempo Traveller that drove to Greenways Road, a leafy neighbourhood in Madras. When the vehicle turned into an old bungalow, I had little idea that this would be my home for another ten days.

The colonial-age building stood on a huge wooded campus. The ground was carpeted by dry leaves and fallen flowers from yellow pods. Adding to the coolness of the Tamil month of *Margazhi* was the shade thrown by the canopy of hundred-year-old trees. Not a bad place, considering that the Latex Guest House and Pallipuram camps were my shelters for the past ten days.

The comfort was short-lived. I made a few inquiries and was told that the bungalow was the famous 'Malligai', used by the Special Investigation Team that probed the Rajiv Gandhi assassination case to interrogate the accused three years earlier. Third degree measures used to extract information from the Rajiv case accused were popular. A shiver ran down my spine.